The Age of Discovery and Maritime Trade Routes

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1. THE FALL OF CONSTANTINOPLE AND THE SPICE TRADE

The Age of Discovery, spanning the 15th to the 17th centuries, marked a radical shift in global trade and geopolitics. For centuries, European access to highly lucrative Asian spices (pepper, cinnamon, nutmeg) and luxury goods was mediated by Islamic empires and Italian city-states (like Venice and Genoa) that controlled the Mediterranean and overland Silk Road routes. The capture of Constantinople by the Ottoman Empire in 1453 severely disrupted these networks, imposing heavy taxes on Christian merchants. This economic strangulation compelled Western European powers—primarily Portugal and Spain—to seek direct, oceanic routes to the East Indies.

2. PORTUGUESE MARITIME INNOVATIONS

Portugal, positioned on the extreme western edge of Europe, pioneered the era of oceanic exploration. Under the patronage of Prince Henry the Navigator, the Portuguese synthesized maritime technologies from various cultures. They developed the *caravel*, a highly maneuverable ship combining European square-rigged sails (for speed) with Arab lateen sails (for sailing close to the wind). They also refined the use of the astrolabe and magnetic compass for open-ocean navigation. Throughout the 15th century, Portuguese explorers systematically mapped the western coast of Africa, establishing a lucrative trade in gold and enslaved people, culminating in Vasco da Gama's successful voyage around the Cape of Good Hope to India in 1498.

3. THE SPANISH CONQUESTS AND THE NEW WORLD

While Portugal pursued an eastern route around Africa, the Spanish Crown (Ferdinand and Isabella) sponsored the Genoese navigator Christopher Columbus in 1492 to reach Asia by sailing west across the Atlantic. Instead of Asia, Columbus encountered the Americas. This accidental discovery initiated the Spanish colonization of the New World. Utilizing superior steel weaponry, firearms, and exploiting indigenous rivalries, conquistadors like Hernán Cortés and Francisco Pizarro rapidly decimated the Aztec and Incan empires. The most devastating weapon, however, was the inadvertent introduction of Old World diseases, which wiped out up to 90% of the indigenous population.

4. THE TREATY OF TORDESILLAS

To prevent a devastating war over newly discovered territories, Spain and Portugal appealed to the Pope. In 1494, they signed the Treaty of Tordesillas, drawing a longitudinal Line of Demarcation approximately halfway between the Cape Verde islands and the islands discovered by Columbus. Spain was granted exclusive rights to all lands west of the line (most of the Americas), while Portugal claimed everything to the east (Brazil, Africa, and the Asian trade routes). This treaty ignored the sovereignty of indigenous populations and legally divided the globe between two Iberian powers.

5. THE GLOBAL ECONOMIC SHIFT

The Age of Discovery catalyzed the first true era of globalized trade. The influx of massive quantities of silver from the Spanish mines of Potosí in South America fueled the global economy, financing European trade with Ming Dynasty China. The locus of European wealth and power shifted decisively away from the Mediterranean to Atlantic-facing nations (Spain, Portugal, and subsequently England, France, and the Netherlands). This period also saw the establishment of the Transatlantic Slave Trade and the mercantilist economic systems that would dominate international relations for centuries.